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Iran, the Strait of Hormuz, and an RMB Toll: Realistic Feasibility and Market Consequences

Executive summary

Iran **cannot lawfully impose a generalized “toll” for mere transit** through the Strait of Hormuz under the widely accepted *transit passage* framework for international straits. In the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), all ships enjoy a right of transit passage “which shall not be impeded,” and “there shall be no suspension of transit passage.” [1] In addition, UNCLOS separately bars charges “by reason only of … passage through the territorial sea,” allowing charges only for “specific services rendered.” [2] A broad, mandatory toll for transit would therefore be treated by most states as **inconsistent with the legal regime** that protects chokepoint navigation.

That said, **legal illegitimacy does not preclude coercive enforcement**. Iran may be able to create a *de facto* toll in practice—especially during heightened conflict—by (i) threatening or attacking non-compliant shipping and (ii) offering a “safe passage corridor” or “clearance” process that ships comply with to reduce risk. A March 2026 U.S. Congressional Research Service (CRS) report (republished by USNI) assessed Iran has the capacity to disrupt shipping via mines, speedboats, submarines, shore-based cruise missiles, aircraft, and other systems—and that restoring shipping could take “days, weeks, or perhaps months,” depending on Iranian tactics. [3] Recent reporting also describes an IRGC “tolled passageway” attempt that (per the report) routed ships through Iranian territorial waters around Larak Island, after vessels had been favoring Omani waters. [4]

Requiring payment in Chinese renminbi (RMB) is mechanically feasible but strategically fragile. Payments could be routed via *offshore RMB (CNH)* and/or China’s Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS), which is built to clear/settle cross-border RMB payments. [5] Yet the global financial system remains deeply dollar-centric across reserves, invoicing, and FX liquidity: global FX turnover reached **$9.6 trillion/day** in April 2025 with USD on one side of **89.2%** of trades; RMB’s share was **8.5%**. [6] Official reserves totaled **$13.14 trillion** in 2025Q4; USD’s share was **56.77%** and RMB’s share **1.95%**. [7]

Bottom line: an RMB-denominated toll—if attempted—would most likely **(a)** raise short-term energy risk premia and intermittently disrupt shipping, **(b)** produce **symbolic** “de-dollarization” headlines, but **(c)** have **limited direct impact** on USD reserve status and global settlement architecture unless it becomes a wider, durable shift in *oil pricing/invoicing* and is backed by sustained Chinese institutional support. The largest market impacts would come from **physical disruption risk** (oil/LNG supply, insurance, freight) rather than from the currency denomination of the toll itself. [8]

What is at stake in Hormuz and why a “toll” matters

The Strait of Hormuz is an unusually high-impact chokepoint because it concentrates both **flow volume** and **limited bypass capacity**:

- **Oil and refined products:** EIA estimates oil flow through Hormuz averaged **20 million barrels/day in 2024** (about **20% of global petroleum liquids consumption**) and that Hormuz volumes were **more than one-quarter of global seaborne oil trade**. [9] The IEA similarly states that roughly **20 mb/d** transited in 2025 and that around **25% of the world’s seaborne oil trade** passes through the Strait, with bypass options limited. [10]
- **LNG:** EIA estimates **~20% of global LNG trade** transited Hormuz in 2024, driven mainly by Qatar; Qatar exported about **9.3 Bcf/d** and the UAE **0.7 Bcf/d** through Hormuz. [11] The IEA notes a closure would strand exports from Qatar and UAE representing about **19% of global LNG trade**. [10]
- **Geography and traffic lanes:** the IEA notes the Strait is only **29 nautical miles** wide at its narrowest and uses **two 2-mile shipping channels** plus a **2-mile buffer**. [12] Maritime reporting indicates that at the narrowest point, both inbound and outbound channels can lie in **Omani waters**, and recent traffic has attempted to avoid Iranian waters when risk rises—underscoring that Iran’s “jurisdictional” control is incomplete even though its **military reach** can extend across the Strait. [13]

These baseline facts imply that any credible “toll” regime is less about lawful taxation and more about **coercive leverage** over a critical artery.

Feasibility of an RMB toll

International law and Iran’s treaty posture

Under UNCLOS Part III (straits used for international navigation), **transit passage must not be impeded and cannot be suspended**. [1] This is the core legal obstacle to a unilateral, mandatory toll regime.

While Iran has sometimes argued it is not bound by UNCLOS transit-passage obligations, the UN Treaty Collection shows Iran **signed UNCLOS on 10 Dec 1982** but (on the treaty status page) **does not show a ratification/accession date**, i.e., it is a signatory but not a party. [14] Iran also filed interpretive declarations at signature arguing certain UNCLOS provisions (explicitly including **transit passage**) were “quid pro quo” treaty bargains that only **states parties** should benefit from—signaling Iran’s legal theory for resisting the transit passage regime. [15]

However, most maritime powers treat transit passage through international straits as a foundational rule of navigation and typically act (including via freedom of navigation practice) as if those rules reflect broadly accepted norms. A toll would thus likely be framed internationally as **unlawful interference** with navigation even if Iran claims non-party status. [16]

Practical enforcement: what Iran can and cannot control

A realistic “toll” requires enforcement credibility across three dimensions: **detection**, **interdiction/attack capability**, and **credible commitment** (willingness to bear escalation costs).

Iran's coercive tools: CRS assessed Iran can disrupt shipping with mines, fast boats, submarines, shore-based cruise missiles and other systems, but also noted a U.S.-led restoration effort could take from days to months depending on tactics. [3] Independent expert commentary similarly emphasizes that geography and Iran's arsenal (including mines and anti-ship missiles) can make the Strait a dangerous operating environment. [17]

Limits on "jurisdictional" capture: shipping lanes can be routed to reduce time in Iranian waters; maritime reporting describes traffic deliberately staying within Omani waters in parts of the Strait during elevated risk. [13] This means a toll framed as an exercise of **coastal state regulatory authority** over its territorial sea would be hard to apply universally without becoming a **threat-based regime** (attacking or seizing ships regardless of where they sail).

What "enforcement" looks like in practice: a USNI report describes an IRGC attempt to create a "tollbooth" passageway routing ships through Iranian territorial waters around Larak Island—suggesting Iran can try to *manufacture compliance* by making the non-toll route more dangerous, and the toll route "safer," rather than by exercising lawful tax authority. [4]

Likely naval/UN responses:
A toll that impedes transit passage would probably trigger (i) expanded naval escort operations, ISR, and mine countermeasures; (ii) intensified sanctions and legal-diplomatic pressure; and (iii) possible attempts at multilateral mandates—but with veto risks in the UN Security Council in many geopolitical configurations. The key point for markets is that even if Iran can *start* a coercive toll, sustaining it depends on whether a coalition can credibly **reduce the risk premium** for non-compliance (escorts, air/missile defense, mine clearing) faster than Iran can **reimpose** it (mines, drones, missiles). CRS explicitly highlights uncertainty on how long normalization would take and that a prolonged disruption would create unprecedented oil-market conditions. [3]

How Iran could demand RMB: plausible channels and chokepoints

"Demanding RMB" is not a single mechanism; it is a menu of contractual and payment-rail choices, each constrained by bank compliance and sanctions risk.

Direct RMB settlement via CIPS and CNH:
CIPS is designed to clear and settle cross-border RMB payments (unlike SWIFT, which is primarily a messaging system). [18] CIPS reports **180 trillion RMB** annual business volume in 2025 and lists **193 direct** and **1,573 indirect** participants (as of early April 2026 on its site). [19] This is the cleanest "plumbing" route for RMB-denominated tolls if participating banks are willing.

But CIPS does not fully escape the existing ecosystem: major reporting indicates CIPS has partnered with SWIFT and uses SWIFT messaging for international payments while also having its own messaging capability; it remains much smaller in global reach than SWIFT. [20]

Bilateral oil-for-RMB structures (China-Iran):
Iran has unusually strong incentives to transact with China outside the dollar system because China is the dominant buyer of Iranian exports under sanctions pressure. A U.S. government research primer estimates Chinese purchases account for **~90% of Iran's exported oil**. [21] In that setting, Iran could attempt to link "clearance" or "safe passage" to **yuan-denominated offtake** and Chinese-linked shipping/insurance.

Escrow and “clearance” models:
A coercive toll regime could operate like an escrowed “security deposit” tied to passage clearance (release upon successful transit). The key constraint is not the escrow concept but **bank willingness** and the legal/compliance acceptability of participating in a scheme that many jurisdictions would view as extortionate or sanctionable.

Barter and non-bank settlement:
Iran could attempt non-dollar, non-bank mechanisms (barter, offsets, commodity swaps). These approaches scale poorly for global shipping because they are frictional and hard to standardize, but they can support *selective* corridors.

RMB is not the main constraint; compliance is.
Even if RMB liquidity is available offshore, global shipping participants (shipowners, charterers, insurers) are typically highly compliance-sensitive. A universal “RMB-only” toll would likely concentrate participation among actors already willing to operate in gray-zone conditions.

Scenario analysis with probabilities and timelines

Scenarios and subjective probabilities

Because key assumptions are unspecified (toll size, duration, China’s cooperation level, and sanctions response), the most useful structure is scenario-based rather than point-forecast.

Scenario	What Iran tries to do	Enforcement feasibility	RMB feasibility	Time window	Subjective probability	Market “center of gravity”
Best case	Announces toll, but backs down quickly under pressure; no durable collection	Low: navies, insurers, and Oman channel-routing undermine compliance	Low: no time to operationalize wide RMB collection	Days–weeks	35%	Risk premium fades; partial reversal in oil/gas
Most likely	**Selective coercive corridor**: “clearance” for some ships; sporadic incidents keep a risk premium	Medium: Iran can raise risk; sustaining stable toll is hard	Medium: RMB for a subset of actors via CNH/CIPS	Weeks–months	50%	Higher oil/LNG vol; shipping/insurance costs; episodic risk-off

Scenario	What Iran tries to do	Enforcement feasibility	RMB feasibility	Time window	Subjective probability	Market "center of gravity"
Worst case	Sustained de facto control: broad compliance under threat, toll becomes quasi-regular; RMB preferred	Medium in disruption, low in durable legitimacy	Medium: RMB settlement possible with Chinese facilitation, but sanctions risk high	Months+	15%	Persistent energy shock; trade finance stress; higher inflation risk

The "most likely" scenario aligns with CRS framing that Iran can disrupt and that restoration/normalization could take a meaningful period depending on tactics, with outcomes highly path-dependent. [3]

Mermaid timeline: how an RMB toll regime could evolve

```
timeline
  title Potential evolution of an Iran-imposed RMB toll attempt in Hormuz
  section Initiation
    Policy signal / "toll" announcement : Iran issues decree / IRGC guidance
    Initial market shock               : Brent/LNG spike, insurance reprices
  section Coercive phase
    Shipping adapts routes             : More time in Omani waters; traffic
drops
    Iran tests interdiction            : Limited seizures/attacks to enforce
compliance
    "Clearance corridor" forms         : Some ships transit using Iranian waters
corridor
  section Payments & settlement
    RMB channels piloted               : CNH/CIPS payments used for subset of
transits
    Sanctions & compliance response    : Secondary-sanctions threats; bank de-
risking
  section Resolution paths
    Diplomatic settlement              : Toll ends or becomes symbolic
    or Limited normalization           : Corridor persists; high risk premium
remains
    or Escalation                      : Wider conflict, prolonged disruption/
closure
```

Quantitative impacts on USD reserve status, settlement systems, and FX markets

Direct “RMB toll” flows are tiny relative to FX and reserve aggregates

A useful discipline is to compare *plausible toll receipts* to the scale of global FX markets and central bank reserves.

Using EIA’s **~20 mb/d** oil flow through the Strait [9] :

Annual barrels through Hormuz:
20 mb/d × 365 ≈ **7.3 billion barrels/year** (order-of-magnitude).

If a hypothetical toll were **$1 per barrel**, annual toll payments would be about **$7.3 billion/year**—and **$20 million/day**.

Compare those flows to:

- **Global FX market turnover: $9.6 trillion/day** (April 2025). [6]
  A $20m/day RMB purchase to pay a toll would be ~**0.0002%** of daily global FX turnover (mechanically negligible).
- **Global official FX reserves: $13.14 trillion** (2025Q4). [7]
  Even an unrealistic “all toll receipts become RMB reserves” would shift global reserve shares by **only a few basis points**.

The chart below visualizes an **upper bound**: if *all annual toll receipts* were effectively shifted from USD reserves to RMB reserves (a heroic assumption), the global USD/RMB reserve shares barely move.

(Chart uses baseline COFER shares for 2025Q4. [22])

Settlement systems: what actually changes if payment is in RMB?

Messaging vs settlement layers matter.

- **SWIFT** is the dominant global financial messaging layer; it is widely described as systemically important for cross-border transactions. [23]
- **CIPS** clears/settles RMB payments for participating banks and can optionally use its own messaging, but also interfaces with SWIFT messaging. [24]
- **Dollar settlement infrastructure** remains extremely deep. A New York Fed staff report notes that **CHIPS** clears and settles about **$1.8 trillion/day** and **Fedwire** supports nearly **$4 trillion/day** in wire transfers (reported figures). [25]

Implication: even if Iran forces a subset of payments into RMB rails, it does not “replace” global dollar settlement. It **reroutes marginal flows**—likely via offshore CNH and/or CIPS—while most global trade finance and liquidity management remains USD-centric.

RMB's global payments footprint remains modest. SWIFT's Global Currency Tracker reports RMB was **2.73%** of global payments by value in Dec 2025 and **3.13%** in Jan 2026. [26] This matters because it limits how quickly a broad shipping industry can pivot operationally.

Oil invoicing vs oil settlement: why "petroyuan" effects are hard

A key analytical distinction:

- **Invoicing/pricing currency:** what the contract price is quoted in (and what benchmarks/derivatives are built on).
- **Settlement currency:** what money actually changes hands (which can be converted at execution time).

Even if some cargoes settle in RMB, oil price discovery is still heavily influenced by benchmarks quoted in USD (e.g., Brent/WTI as tracked in USD terms by major data providers and official statistics). [27] Moreover, BIS analysis highlights that "most commodities are priced in dollars," so USD moves mechanically transmit into commodity price dynamics for non-US economies. [28]

For a true structural shift, the world would need (i) a large, liquid RMB commodity derivatives ecosystem used by global hedgers and (ii) a willingness among major exporters/importers to take RMB balance-sheet risk at scale—both challenging under capital controls and sanctions uncertainty.

Reserve currency status: the toll's most plausible channel is indirect and political

The USD reserve share is drifting lower over long horizons, but remains dominant: in 2025Q4 COFER, USD is **56.77%** vs RMB **1.95%**. [7] IMF analysis emphasizes the USD decline over decades has not translated into proportional gains for other "big" currencies; diversification has partly gone into "nontraditional" reserve currencies, and RMB reserve share shows signs of stalling post-2022. [29]

Therefore, the **most realistic channel** from an "RMB toll" to USD reserve status is not mechanical flow, but **policy reaction**:

- If the event increases perceptions of dollar "weaponization" (sanctions, asset freezes) and encourages bloc formation, some central banks may diversify marginally. IMF research suggests, however, that the pace of reserve-share change is generally slow. [30]
- Trade invoicing patterns remain sticky. An IMF working paper with data through 2023 finds the USD remains the dominant invoicing currency, while RMB growth exists but remains modest. [31] The ECB similarly reports USD and euro together account for **over 80%** of global trade invoicing, based on new IMF/ECB data. [32]

FX, rates, commodities, and trade finance transmission

FX rates * **Immediate shock (days–weeks):** Hormuz disruption risk is typically risk-off and energy-inflationary. Risk-off tends to support USD versus high-beta and EM FX; energy importers' currencies can weaken on terms-of-trade pressure. This channel is larger than any incremental RMB demand from toll payments because global FX turnover is enormous. [33]
*CNH/CNY:** an RMB settlement push could create episodic CNH demand, but RMB's managed regime and onshore/offshore segmentation can limit free-market pass-through. RMB's small reserve share (1.95%) and

modest payments share (~3%) imply limited immediate capacity to absorb large global settlement shifts without policy accommodation. [34]

Rates and bond yields * **Inflation channel:** oil/LNG spikes raise near-term inflation expectations; this can steepen front-end rate pricing (hawkish repricing). CRS notes the magnitude/duration is uncertain and depends on how quickly Middle East oil trade normalizes. [3]
*Risk-off channel:** global growth fears can drive duration demand (bull flattening). Net outcome depends on central bank reaction functions and whether the shock looks like supply inflation vs demand destruction.

Commodity prices * **Oil and LNG:** direct supply disruption dominates. EIA and IEA emphasize limited bypass capacity and high shares of global oil/LNG flows through Hormuz. [35]
*Gold:** tends to benefit from geopolitical risk and sanctions uncertainty; IMF commentary notes sanctions risk can influence reserve behavior, including gold accumulation, though gold remains historically low as a reserve share. [29]

Global trade finance * A Hormuz shock strains trade finance through higher insurance/freight, longer routes, and higher working capital needs (larger margining for commodity hedges, larger letters of credit, etc.).
* RMB's trade-finance role is rising but still far from dethroning USD; public reporting citing SWIFT data notes RMB has become a meaningful trade-finance currency in recent years, but USD remains the dominant funding/invoicing anchor for most global corporates. [36]

Trade ideas by scenario with triggers and risk management

These are scenario frameworks for education and idea generation, not individualized investment advice. Markets can gap, liquidity can vanish, and geopolitical headlines can reverse quickly.

Scenario-to-instrument map

Scenario	Primary risk	Instruments most affected	Dominant P/L drivers
Best case (de-escalation)	Risk premium mean reversion	Brent/WTI vol, tanker rates, safe-haven FX	Vol crush; oil pullback; USD gives back risk-off gains
Most likely (selective corridor)	High vol / episodic shocks	Oil, LNG (TTF/JKM proxies), shipping, USD funding	Tail hedges pay; carry is costly; dispersion rises
Worst case (prolonged disruption)	Energy supply shock + stagflation	Oil & products cracks, European gas, inflation breakevens, EM	Convexity (calls), inflation hedges, EM divergence (importers vs exporters)

Concrete trade structures

Trade idea	Direction / structure	Horizon	Entry triggers	Exit triggers	Key risks / hedges
Oil disruption convexity	**Long Brent calls or call spreads** (e.g., 1–3 month tenor), optionally financed by selling farther OTM calls ("ratio" only if risk-tolerant)	Days–weeks	Confirmed incident trend (mines/attacks), insurance premium spikes, sharp drop in AIS traffic; widening backwardation	Diplomatic breakthrough; verifiable escort/mine-clear progress; implied vol collapses	Vol crush if de-escalation; manage with defined-risk spreads; hedge with small short energy equities if needed
LNG shock asymmetry	**Long European gas (TTF) optionality** or structured exposure via energy equities with gas leverage	Days–weeks	Evidence LNG transit halts; Asian spot bids jump; European storage stress	Restoration of LNG sailings; coordinated stock releases; weather shifts	Gas is extremely volatile; position size small; use options
USD risk-off basket	**Long USD vs high beta** (e.g., AUD, KRW) via options to cap downside	Days–weeks	Oil spike + equity selloff + higher VIX; widening credit spreads	Ceasefire signals; oil retraces; equities stabilize	If oil spike hurts USD via terms-of-trade narrative; hedge via long JPY/CHF vs USD if needed
Energy importer stress	**Short selected EM FX** of oil importers or **underweight EM equities** with high energy import burden	Weeks	Sustained higher oil; current-account stress signals; rising local inflation expectations	Oil back below pre-shock range; IMF/ support packages	Political intervention risk; use baskets and options
Inflation hedge	**Long U.S. breakevens** (TIPS vs nominals) or **short duration** in vulnerable curves	Weeks–months	Persistent oil > threshold; inflation swap/ breakeven breakouts	Evidence demand destruction dominates; central banks signal tolerance	If risk-off dominates and breakevens compress; hedge duration separately

Trade idea	Direction / structure	Horizon	Entry triggers	Exit triggers	Key risks / hedges
RMB/CNH optionality (tail)	**Long CNH volatility** (USD/CNH options) rather than spot	Weeks	Clear evidence of enforced RMB settlement corridor; CIPS activity surge; offshore CNH funding stress	China signals support/controls; corridor ends	Policy-managed FX; spot may not move; options preferred

Why options dominate here: the risk distribution is fat-tailed and headline-driven. Options (or defined-risk spreads) help prevent a single ceasefire headline from wiping out a directional position.

Assumptions and what is not specified

Your prompt correctly notes several critical unknowns. The conclusions above depend on how these resolve:

Scale of toll:
A per-voyage toll (e.g., "$2m per VLCC") has very different macro implications than a per-barrel toll. Even a $1/bbl toll on ~20 mb/d is only ~$7.3b/year—small macro-financially, large politically. [37]

Enforcement duration:
Short disruptions mostly drive **volatility**; multi-month disruptions drive **macro regime shifts** (inflation expectations, recession odds). CRS explicitly flags outcomes depend on time to normalize flows and that unprecedented conditions could result if disruption is prolonged. [38]

China's cooperation level:
RMB settlement at scale requires not just willingness to buy Iranian oil but also banking/clearing support that can withstand sanction threats. CIPS provides infrastructure and has expanding participation, but is not yet a SWIFT-scale substitute. [39]

Sanctions response function:
If the U.S. and allies respond mainly with secondary sanctions and aggressive interdiction, banks and insurers will de-risk quickly, limiting the practical scope of RMB toll collection. If policy prioritizes stabilizing oil prices and tolerates limited gray-zone trade, the corridor could persist longer.

Key analytic conclusion under uncertainty:
An RMB toll is best viewed as **a lever for selective coercion** and sanctions circumvention rather than as a credible catalyst for rapid displacement of the USD. The USD's role is supported by deep FX liquidity [6], dominant reserve holdings [7], and sticky invoicing patterns [40]—all of which are far larger than any plausible tolled-flow RMB demand.

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